DAS COMPETITION
IDEATION



WHAT IS **IDEATION?**

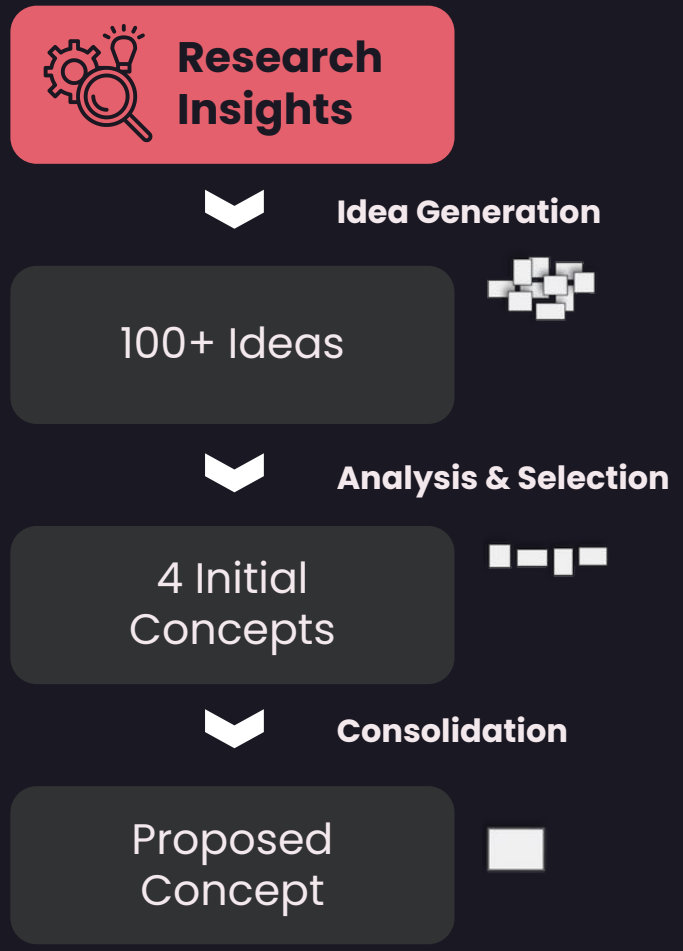
Ideation is the process of generating, downselecting and refining ideas.

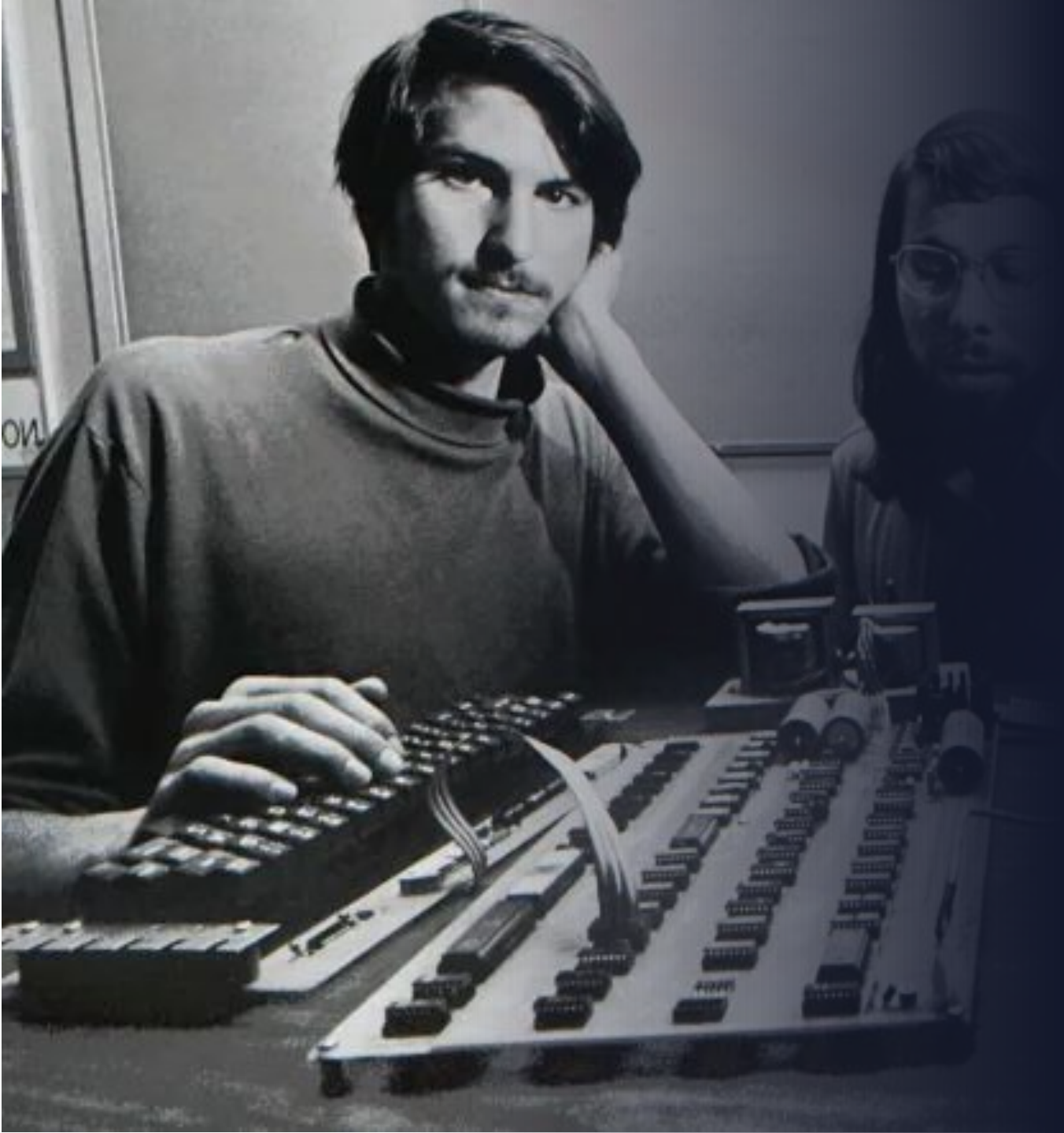
It lays the foundation for innovation, differentiation, and market potential.



OVERVIEW

- Define the problem space.
- Generate a large quantity of ideas.
- Evaluate, prioritize, downselect ideas.
- Refine and iterate on the most promising ones.





“You have to start with the customer experience and work your way backwards to the technology.

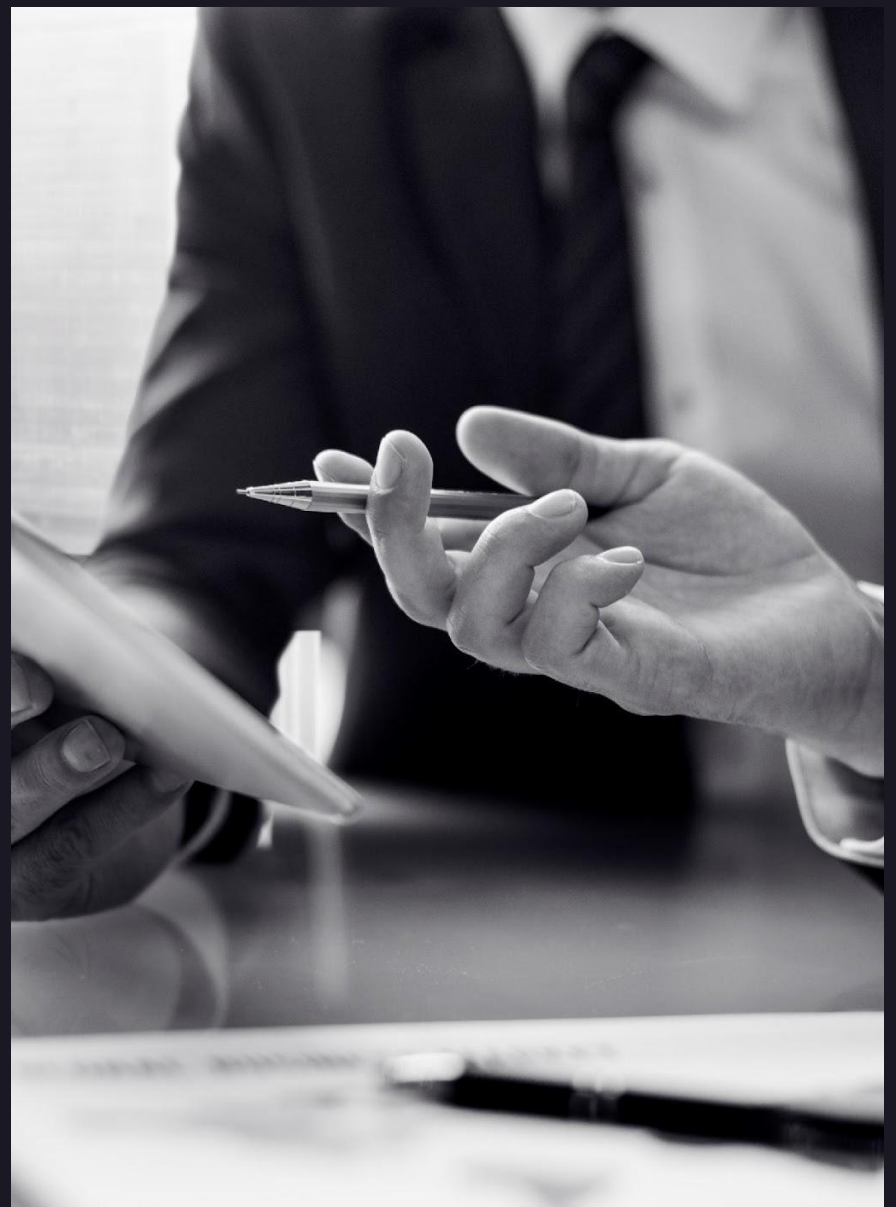
You cannot start with the technology and try to figure out where to sell it”

Steve Jobs

STEP 1

DEFINE THE **PROBLEM**

- Understand the pain points and challenges faced by your target customers.
- Conduct market research to identify gaps and opportunities.
- How is the problem currently being solved? What are the pros/cons to those solutions?



STEP 2

WHO IS THE **CUSTOMER?**

- Understand the pain points and challenges faced by your target customers.
- Conduct market research to identify gaps and opportunities.
- How is the problem currently being solved? What are the pros/cons to those solutions?



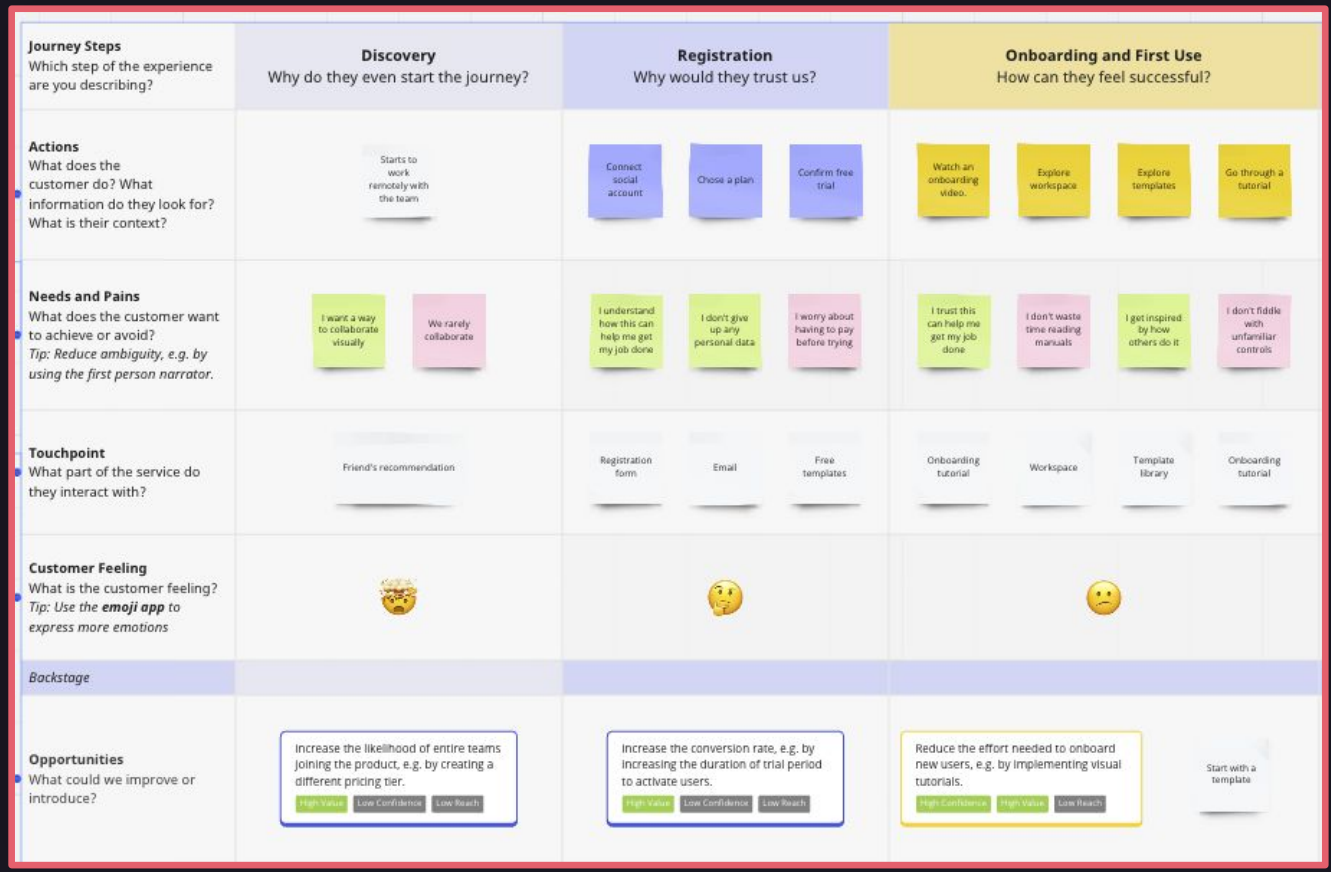
STEP 3

WHAT IS THE **USER'S JOURNEY?**

What are the steps the user currently goes through?

What is the user's goal at each step? What are the pain points and opportunities?

How is the problem currently being solved? What are the pros/cons to those solutions?



GENERATE **IDEAS**

The first step is a large volume of ideas!

Schedule brainstorming sessions

- Create a supportive environment where no idea is dismissed initially.

- Use techniques like mind mapping, idea boards, and ideation workshops.



HOW MIGHT WE?

... REDUCE TOILET WATER CONSUPTION AT HOME?

... IMPROVE PUBLIC PLAYGROUNDS TO REDUCE TOXIC STRESS IN LOW-INCOME AND UNHOUSED CHILDREN?

... REDUCE URBAN RUNOFF

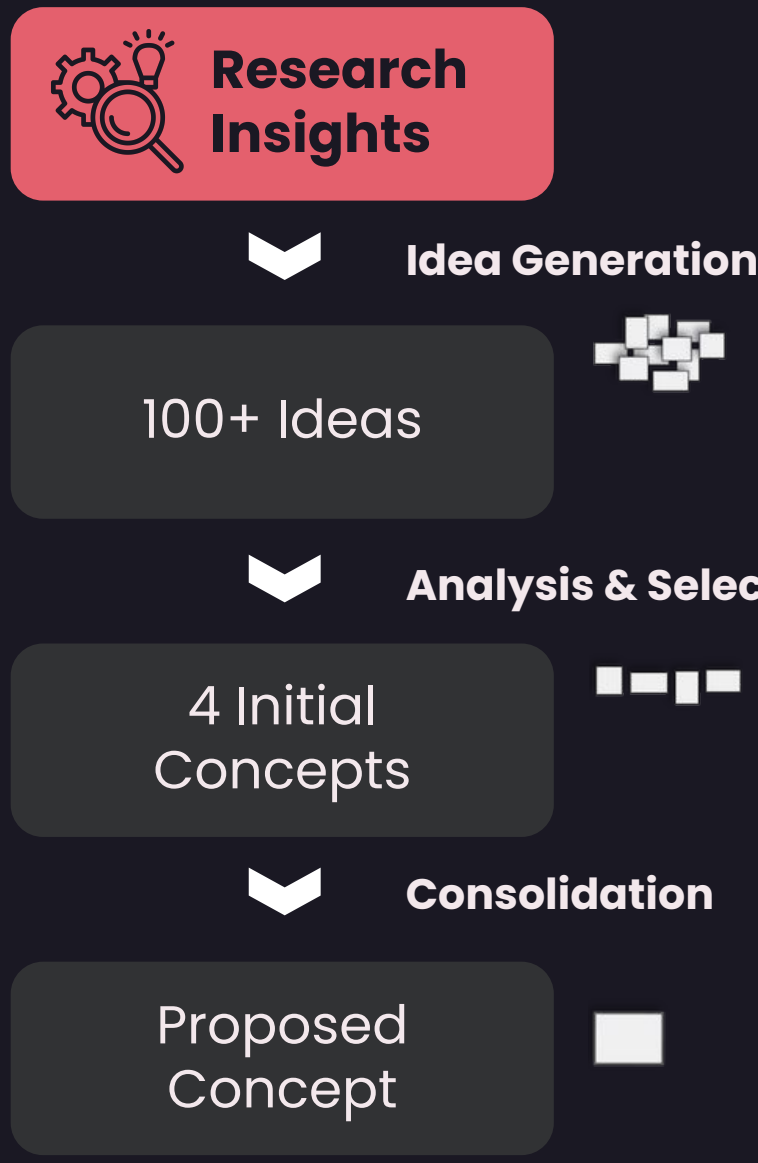
... REDUCE LANDFILL WASTE DUE TO THROWN AWAY CLOTHING

... REDUCE PARTICULATE POLLUTION IN URBAN ENVIRONMENTS

... REDUCE POWER GRID LOAD FROM ELECTRIC SCOOTERS

ITERATIVE IDEATION PROCESS

- Align on your criteria
- Generate ideas (no judgement yet)
- Group into themes
- Combine and Refine ideas within themes
- Evaluate against Criteria
- Downselect ideas and Refine them
- Evaluate against Criteria
- Downselect again



BRAINSTORMING **TECHNIQUES**

- NO BAD IDEAS- do not criticize or judge
- Start idea generation individually, post on wall, but you can steal and improve

Brainstorming Methods

- Braindump- generate as many ideas as possible
- How might we?
- Blue Sky ideation
- Biomimicry- steal from nature
- Crazy ideas only
- Round robin- build on each other's ideas
- Challenge existing assumptions



Sort ideas into themes and combine

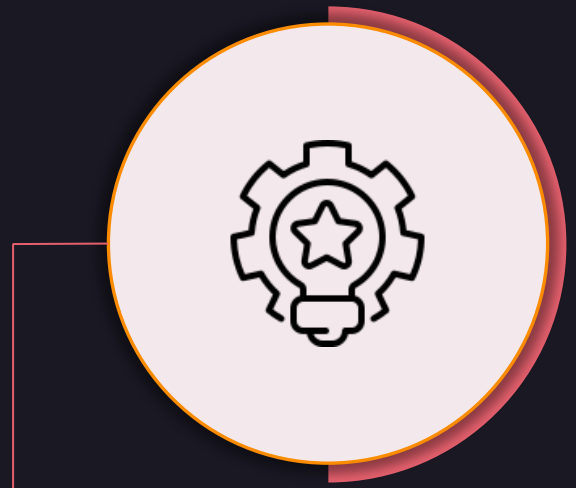
Dot voting- everyone votes for favorites with a dot on the post-it

STEP 3

EVALUATION



Assess the feasibility, market potential, and alignment with your vision.



Consider the scalability, competitiveness, and unique value of each idea.



Use criteria such as customer impact, market size, and technical viability.

IDEA EVALUATION **CRITERIA**

- **Customer Impact**
  How well does the idea solve a real pain point?
- **Market Potential**
  Is there a sizable market for the solution?
- **Technical Viability**
  Connect unrelated elements to trigger new ideas.
- **Competitive Advantage**
  Challenge assumptions and reverse problem statements.



COMPETITIVE **BENCHMARKING**

What's your competitive advantage?

Define the Benchmarking Metrics

- Determine specific criteria for comparison (e.g., pricing, features, customer service).

Identify Competitors

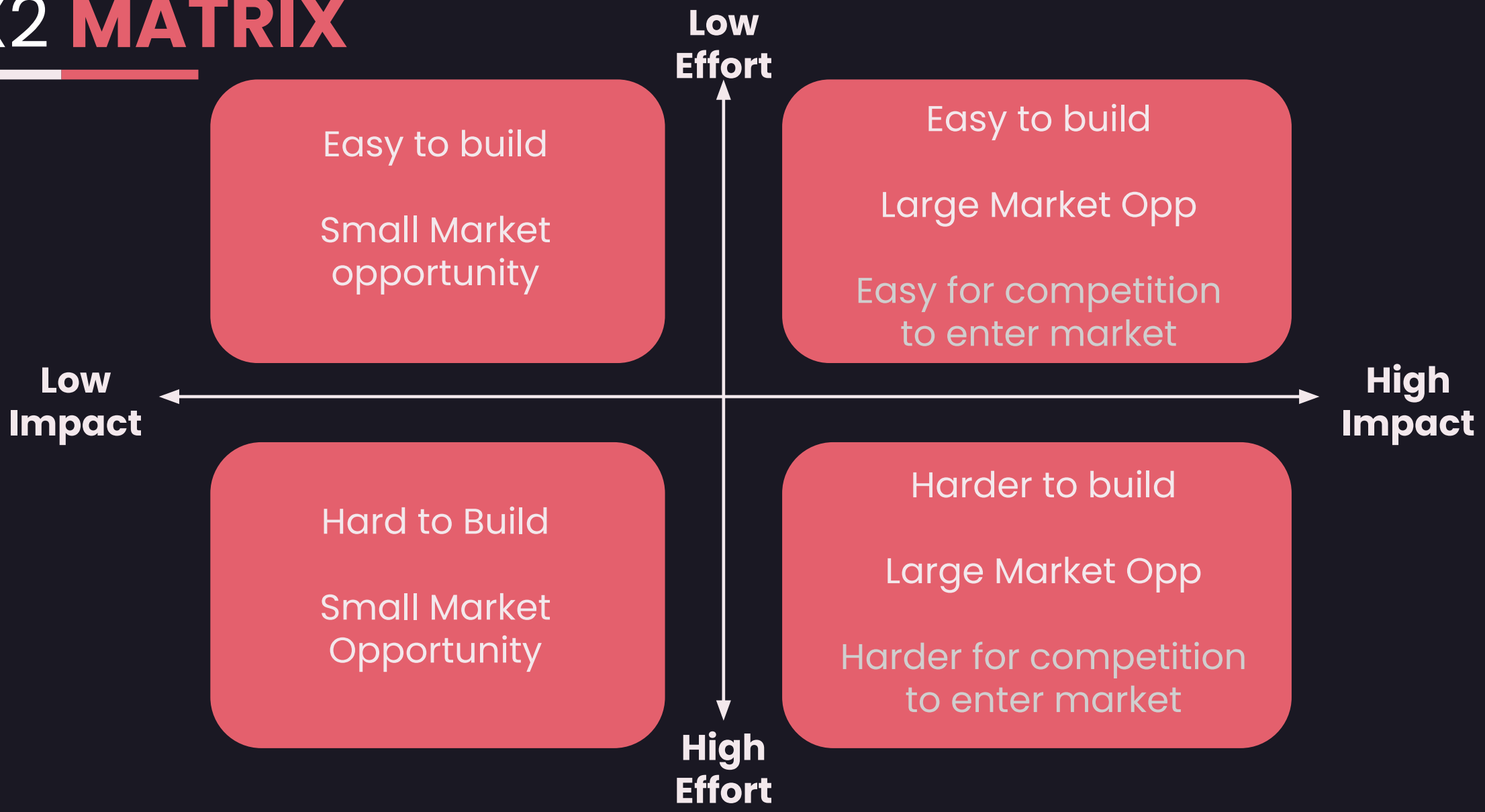
- Identify direct competitors and companies known for excellence in your industry.
- Look for startups with successful practices that align with your goals

Gather Data

- Use public sources, competitor websites, customer reviews, and industry reports.
- Analyze data on product features, pricing, market share, customer satisfaction



2X2 MATRIX


Low Effort
Easy to build
Small Market opportunity
Easy to build
Large Market Opp
Easy for competition to enter market
Low Impact
High Impact
Hard to Build
Small Market Opportunity
Harder to build
Large Market Opp
Harder for competition to enter market
High Effort

SWOT

	HELPFUL	HARMFUL
INTERNAL	**Strengths** • What do we do well? • What do our customers or Partners like about us? • In what areas do we outpace our competitors? • What's unique about our Business, products, or services? • What assets do we own (IP, skills, etc)	**Weaknesses** • What can we improve? • What are our customers or partners dissatisfied with? • Where do we fall behind our competitors? • Where are we lacking in knowledge or resources?
EXTERNAL	**Opportunities** • What emerging trends can we take advantage of? • Which of our strengths might be valuable to potential partners? • What adjacent markets might we tap into? • Are there geographic locations with less competition?	**Threats** • What is our competition doing? • How could our weaknesses leave • us vulnerable? • What market trends are • we unprepared for? • What economic or political issues could impact our business?

SWOT

CRITICAL **ASPECTS**

Customer Impact

- Be truthful when assessing strengths and weaknesses.
- Avoid biases and wishful thinking to get an accurate view.

Focus on Relevance

- Prioritize factors that directly impact your startup's success.
- Filter out less relevant aspects to stay focused.

Action-Oriented Insights

- Use SWOT analysis to inform your decision-making.
- Turn insights into actionable strategies



REFINE AND **ITERATE**

Select the most promising ideas for further development.

Refine and iterate on the selected ideas through prototyping, feedback, and validation.

Continuously seek input from potential customers to shape and enhance your ideas.



DAS COMPETITION
RESOURCES



2X2 MATRIX


Low
Invest
Delegate
Do First
Low
Impact
High
Impact
Don’t Do
Do Next
High
Invest

IDEA BRAINSTORM
TECHNIQUES

Mind mapping
Visualize ideas and their relationships.

Scamper
Substitute, Combine, Adapt, Modify, Put to another use, Eliminate, Reverse.

Random stimulus
Connect unrelated elements to trigger new ideas.

Reverse thinking
- Challenge assumptions and reverse problem statements.
- Biomimicry



NABC (need, approach, benefit, competition)

Ideation

Planting idea seeds

Overview

- Ensure that all team members have the opportunity to contribute ideas
- Ensure that all team members build upon each other's ideas

1-1.5 hours

Post-it notes

Instructions

1. One team member shares one idea. Make sure to record it on a post-it note. **One idea per post-it note**.
2. Everyone goes around the circle and builds on the idea, for example using "yes, and..." Make sure to record new ideas on new post-it notes.
3. After everyone has contributed to the idea, the next team member shares a different idea and the process repeats.

When you are finished with the activity, you can work at your own pace to continue generating ideas. The goal is to generate 40 ideas.

After generating ideas, **group ideas by solution strategy by physically putting post-it notes together in groups**. For example, ideas that address a problem from a similar angle should be grouped together.

After grouping ideas, label each group by thinking of a name that the idea group represents.

ACTIVITY CARDS - UNLEASH Innovation

Ideation

Pitch your idea concepts

Overview

- Before downselecting ideas, pitch your favorite idea concepts to your team

1 hour

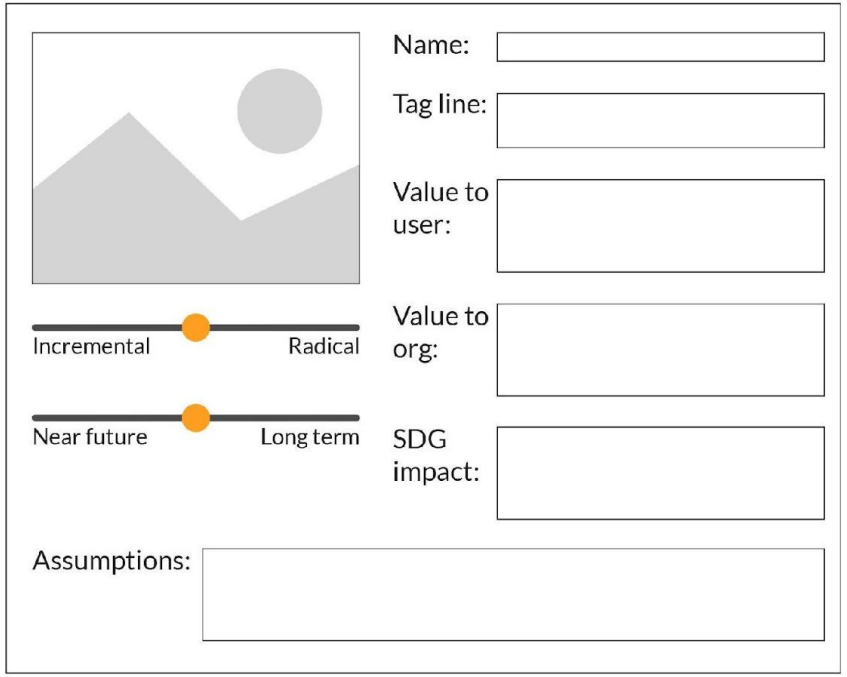
Paper

Instructions

On a large piece of paper, describe your favorite ideas in a bit more depth. One piece of paper per idea. Include:

- **Picture:** A drawing or photo that illustrates your idea
- **Name**: Give your idea a catchy title
- **Tag line**: Describe your idea in one punchy line
- **Value to user**: Why would users want to adopt your solution?
- **Value to organization**: Why would you, another company, another organization, or another stakeholder want to put resources into this?
- **Forecasted impact on SDGs**: What is the impact that this idea would have on the SDGs?
- **Assumptions**: List 3 assumptions that you are making in order for this idea to work
- Rating on a scale from **incremental to radical**
- Rating on a scale of **near future to long term**

See example idea concept drawing on back of the card.



Ideation

Value vs. complexity mapping

Overview

- Assess ideas by how difficult they are to do vs. their impact and value
- Assess *elements* of ideas by how difficult they are to do vs. their impact and value

1 hour

Paper, post-its

Instructions

The value vs. complexity map can be used for both ideas and for elements of ideas.

- **For ideas**: Assess the impact potential of multiple ideas and their likelihood of success. Then select which idea to focus on.
- **For elements of ideas**: Assess the impact potential of a feature of a product or service relative to implementation challenges. Determine which elements of an idea to include in the final solution. This is especially important for solutions that include multiple elements, for example a product that has a light + radio + cell phone charger, or a program that offers skill development + job placement + help with contract negotiation. It is difficult to launch a solution with all elements fully functional from the start, and so you can evaluate the value vs. complexity of individual elements to help prioritize what to focus on first.

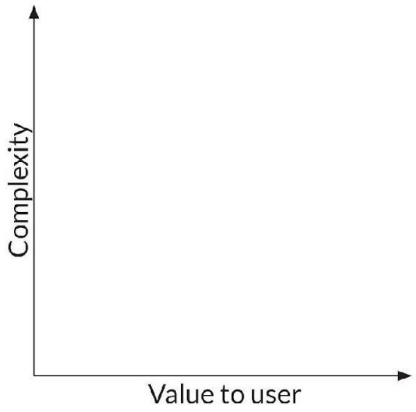
Value vs. complexity

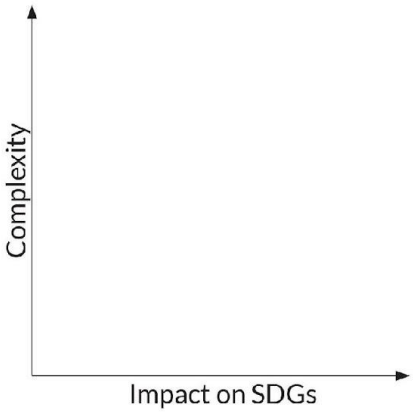
The value vs. complexity map is used to visually evaluate ideas (or elements of ideas) by how much value they have to the user (e.g. how well they address user needs and wants) vs. how difficult or complex they will be to implement (e.g. based on logistics, partnerships, number of moving pieces, etc.)

Impact vs. complexity

The impact vs. complexity map is used to visually evaluate ideas (or elements of ideas) by how much impact they have on the global challenge and SDGs vs. how difficult or complex they will be to implement (e.g. based on logistics, partnerships, number of moving pieces, etc.).

For example, if your idea is a program with several offerings, you can map each element of the program to determine which elements are the most high impact, most high value, and also the most difficult to implement. You want to prioritize elements that are high impact and high value but less difficult to implement, to increase your chances of success. All solutions will likely have complex elements, but these mappings can help ensure that you focus on the one or two complex elements that are most essential for creating a high impact, high value solution.





Ideation

Downselecting ideas

Overview

- Multiple simple tools for helping you downselect ideas so that you can focus on a small number of ideas to prototype and test

1 hour

Paper, post-its

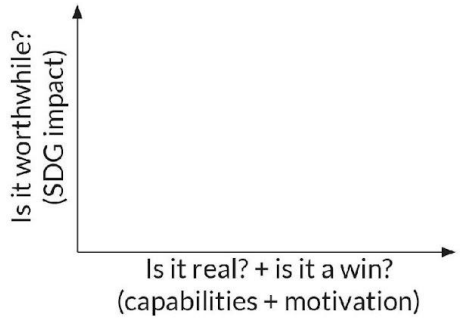
Instructions

Score ideas on desirability, feasibility, and viability

1. Give each idea a score from 1 to 5, where 1 is low and 5 is high, in the following three areas:
   - **Desirability:** Do people want this? Does it fill a need? Is it appealing? Can it fit into people's lives?
   - **Feasibility**: Can we do this? Is the technology needed within reach? Can the organization make it happen?
   - **Viability**: Should we do this? Does it align with our goals? Can we develop, fund, and sustain this?
2. Select the ideas with the highest scores.

Score ideas on RWW

1. Give each idea a score from 1 to 5, where 1 is low and 5 is high, in the following three areas: three areas:
   - **Is it real?** Can we do this? Do we have the capabitilites?
   - **Is it worthwhile?** Is it creating the impact we want?
   - **Is it a win?** Should we do this? Does it align with our goals?
2. Plot the "Is it worthwhile?" (aka impact) score vs. the "Is it real?" + "Is it a win?" scores.



Vote with colored dots / post-its

1. Create a set of evaluation criteria, for example: most / least impactful, most / least innovative, etc.
2. For the "most" winners, assign one color. For the "least" winners, assign another color.
3. For each evaluation criteria, each person gets to place a "most" and a "least" dot or post-it on the solution that they believe best fits these titles.
4. Visually assess your solutions. The ones with the most colored dots or post-its corresponding to positive evaluation criteria should move forward.
5. What appealing aspects are there in the ideas that were the "least" winners? How do you retain those benefits? How do you overcome the negatives in these ideas?

Ideation

Stakeholder perspective mapping

Overview

- Depict the needs, wants, insights, inputs from, and impact on your key stakeholders (users, customers)
- Start speaking to real users and customers

2-3 hours

Paper

Instructions

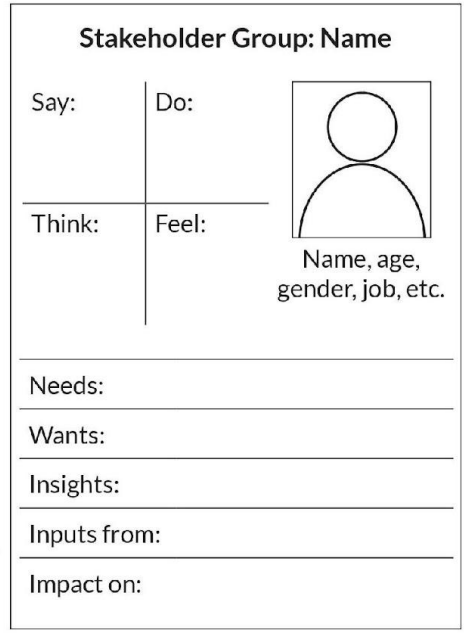
Well-designed solutions are grounded in a deep understanding of all stakeholders involved in the solution, including users (who will use the solution), customers (who will pay for the solution; can be the same profile as users), funders (who will provide capital to launch the solution), and partners (who will help execute the solution). See *Problem Framing: Who is Affected?* and *Problem Framing: User Profile* for more inputs.

Speak to real stakeholders

1. For each stakeholder profile, you want to speak to as many real people as possible. See *Testing: Who to Speak to* for more details on the four above-mentioned stakeholder groups.
2. Take detailed notes on your conversations and record all of your observations. See *Testing: User and Customer Interviews* for more tips on how to speak to stakeholders.

Depict the profiles of your stakeholders on paper

1. On a large sheet of paper, write the name of the stakeholder group and the name of the specific person being profiled at the top.
2. Depict the person's **profile**, such as by drawing an image of the person. Include the following:
   - **Say**: What are quotes or memorable words that the person said?
   - **Do**: What actions or behaviors did the person do?
   - **Think**: Infer what they believe based on what they said and did.
   - **Feel**: Infer what they are feeling based on what they said and did.
3. Outline the following:
   - **Needs:** Needs are verbs (activities and desires) that require help, as opposed to nouns (solutions).
   - **Wants**: Wants are what the person desires or chooses to prioritize, which might conflict with their needs.
   - **Insights**: Record any new insights that arise.
   - **Inputs from**: What inputs you require from the stakeholder to make your solution work.
   - **Impact on**: How your idea (positively and negatively) impacts the stakeholder.
4. Repeat for all stakeholder groups.



Ideation

Value proposition mapping

Overview

- Map the value proposition of your solution to the needs and wants of your key stakeholders (users, customers)

30 minutes

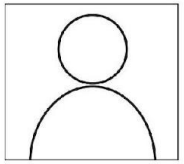
Paper

Instructions

It is important that your solution meets the needs and wants of your key stakeholders, including users (who will use the solution), customers (who will pay for the solution; can be the same profile as users), funders (who will provide capital to launch the solution), and partners (who will help execute the solution). See *Testing: Who to Speak to* for more details on the four above-mentioned stakeholder groups.

1. On a large sheet of paper, write the name of the stakeholder group and the name of the specific person being profiled at the top.

Stakeholder Group: Name



Name, age, gender, job, etc.

	Stakeholder	Solution
Needs	*What the stakeholder requires*	*Value proposition of solution to address needs*
Wants	*What the stakeholder desires*	*Value proposition of solution to address wants*

2. Outline the stakeholder's needs and wants. Note that these are not necessarily the same thing. **Needs** are what the stakeholder requires, while **wants** are what the stakeholder desires.
3. Outline your solution's value proposition, or how your solution addresses both the stakeholder's needs and wants.
4. Repeat for all stakeholder groups.

Ideation

Market research

Overview

- Research market trends, potential competitors, and the successes and failures of similar solutions
- Use past experiences to shape your solution idea/

1-1.5 hours

Paper, post-its

Instructions

It is extremely important to understand what other solutions have tried to address your problem framing in the past, and why they have failed. Hopefully the insights that shaped your problem framing started to highlight some of these issues.

Now is the time to ensure that you fully understand the context in which you will be working. Don't re-invent the wheel. The more you can learn about how others' ideas and solutions have succeeded or failed, the less time, resources and capital you need to spend on re-learning what others have already discovered.

Explore in detail the following three areas:

- **Market trends**: What trends are shaping the future of the market you want to enter with your solution? Where was your market 10 years ago? Where do you think it will be in 10 years?
- **Competitors**: Everyone has competitors. Competitors are other solutions that your users have available or are currently turning to in order to fill their needs. Competitors can also be the status quo. For example, if your user is currently doing nothing to address their problem, than you will have to overcome the behavior of "doing nothing" to have the user adopt your solution. Who are your competitors and what is their behavior like? Why do you users turn to this competitor, or why do they not?
- **Successes and failures of similar solutions**: Who has tried something similar to your solution in the past? This can be similar to your entire solution or simply one aspect / element of your solution. What can you learn from these past successes and failures?

For these three categories:

1. Research each the categories using online search engines, available on-site experts, available remotely based experts, and other UNLEASH SDG Talents (See *Testing: Methods for Answering Questions*).
2. Write your insights on post-its under each of the categories answering the questions: What happened or is going to happen? Why did it happen or why will it happen?
3. Write your responses to the insights you have discovered on post-its, answering the questions: How will you adapt your solution? How does your solution differentiate itself in a way that makes it competitive?

	Trends	Competitors	Successes	Failures
Insights				
Response				

Ideation

PATH Statement

Overview

- Revisit your problem framing to include your solution
- Succinctly define your problem, approach, target, and heart & humanity

30 minutes

Paper

Instructions

A PATH statement is a succinct statement that addresses four elements:

- **Problem**: What problem are you solving?
- **Approach**: How are you solving this problem?
- **Target**: Who are the users and customers that you are reaching with your solution?
- **Heart & Humanity**: What is the impact you are trying to create with this solution and why do you care about creating this impact?

A PATH statement builds upon your problem framing, adding the elements of the proposed solution. For solutions that address global challenges, it is important to include not just the impact that your solution is making, but also your personal passion for solving this challenge, which will help keep you motivated in the face of adversity.

A PATH statement can be a good starting point for a 60 second pitch on your problem and proposed solution.

As you continue through the design process, it is important to re-visit your PATH statement and ensure you are staying on Target and staying true to the Heart & Humanity of the solution.